fibres. This softener should be added in the rinse cycle of washing machine. Fabric softener reduces the absorbency of textiles, which adversely affects the function of towels and microfibre cloth.

Conventional softeners, contain 4–8 % active material, which have been partially replaced in by softener concentrates having some 12–30 % active material.

- **Anionic Fabric Softeners**

Anionic softeners and antistatic agents are often used together with the conventional cationic softeners. Cationic softeners are incompatible with anionic surfactants in detergents because they combine with them to form a solid precipitate. They should be added in the rinse cycle. Anionic softeners can combine with anionic surfactants directly. Some compounds, such as ethoxylate phosphate esters, have softening, anti-static, and surfactant properties.

5.3.2.2 Method of using Fabric Softener

- After pouring in detergent, locate the fabric softener dispenser on your machine.
- Pour in the recommended amount.
- If your machine doesn't have a specific dispenser, you will have to manually add the fabric softener during the last rinse cycle. Do not add fabric softener to the main detergent dispenser because it needs to be used at the end of the wash cycle.
- Never pour fabric softener directly on to clothes.
- Alternatives to using fabric softener can be used as dryer sheets or a combination of detergent with fabric softener.

Most modern washing machines have a dispenser to add liquid fabric softener to the load of laundry automatically on the final rinse. Some brands of washing powder have fabric conditioning it is claimed to save money when compared ordinary washing powder and fabric softener separately.

5.3.3 Starching

Starch is most commonly and widely used stiffening agent. The most appropriate starch for use in laundry is one which penetrates the fabric well to make pliable, smooth and glossy that will prevent direct contact of dirt with fabric. A stiffening starch is applied to cotton and linen fabric only.

5.3.3.1 Types of Starches

The different kinds of starches commonly used as stiffening agents are;

- **Rice Starch**

The grains of this starch are very small and make a viscous solution in water. This starch is suitable for most fabrics. Since starch gelatinizes easily in cold water, it is known as cold water starch. As the size of grains are very small, this penetrates easily into the fabrics.

- **Wheat Starch**

The grains of this starch exist in two sizes large and small. This starch forms a viscous solution leaving fabric very stiff and pliable. It requires boiling of solution and is very uneconomical and expensive.

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